

Giants of the ocean

Among the ocean's best-known animals are sharks, whales, and dolphins. In these groups are some of the largest animals on Earth. They share many of the same features, which help them breathe, feed, and swim underwater. Whales and dolphins are sea mammals, but sharks are fish.

Dorsal fin

Fish and sea mammals have a dorsal fin on their backs to stay upright in the water. This keeps them stable when swimming, and helps them change direction smoothly.

Spinner dolphin



Tail

Powerful tails can push large marine animals through the water. The tails of whales and dolphins go up and down, while the tails of sharks go from side to side.

Cat shark



Bottlenose dolphin



Body

Sharks and dolphins have streamlined shapes and smooth bodies, which are suited to swimming. Torpedo-shaped dolphins can leap out of the water!